



selling it yourself,

Yes, you can.

Here is what it actually takes.

BY

Kim Pelham · The Pelham Group NW

14 YEARS IN REAL ESTATE

Everett, Washington



your neighbor in real estate

hey neighbor,

Most agents will tell you not to do this.

I am not going to do that.

Sometimes selling it yourself is the right call. You already have the buyer. It is going to a family member. You have done this before and the paperwork does not scare you. In those cases you should not be paying a full commission, and I would rather help you than watch you do it alone and get hurt by something you did not know about.

But I am also not going to pretend it is easy, because I have cleaned up enough of these to know better. There are two things that catch almost everybody in Washington. One of them is new, and it is the reason I wrote this guide.

So this is the honest version. What you are actually signing. What changed with Zillow. What it really costs you when you do not offer to pay the buyer's agent. And the two ways I can help without taking a full commission, because both of those exist and hardly anyone knows it.

Read what is useful. Skip what is not. My number is on the last page, and I answer my own phone.

Kim

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Zillow will not *list your house.*

Not in Washington. Not any more. And that is most of your buyers.

If you sold a house by owner a few years ago, you probably posted it on Zillow yourself. That door is closed here now.

Zillow is a member of our MLS. In Washington State that means Zillow does not take for-sale-by-owner listings. Other states still allow owners to post directly. Ours does not. If your house is not in the Northwest MLS, it does not appear on the site nearly every buyer in this county opens first.

I have watched people learn this on day two, after the sign is already in the yard and they have told everyone at work. It is not a small inconvenience. It is the difference between your house being seen and your house being invisible.

What that leaves you. A yard sign. Word of mouth. Facebook groups and Craigslist. Whatever foot traffic your street gets. That can be enough if you already have a buyer. It is rarely enough if you are trying to find one.

5%

OF ALL US HOME SALES LAST YEAR WERE FOR
SALE BY OWNER, AN ALL-TIME LOW

64%

OF THOSE SELLERS SAY THEY DID NOT GET THE
PRICE THEY WANTED

Median FSBO sale price: \$360,000. Median agent-assisted: \$425,000. Part of that gap is mix, because for-sale-by-owner homes skew toward lower-cost, rural and manufactured homes. Part of it is not.

National Association of REALTORS, 2025 Profile of Home Buyers and Sellers.

YOUR ACTUAL OPTIONS

Three ways to do this, *and two of them are mine.*

You do not have to choose between paying a full commission and doing all of it alone.

WHAT YOU GET	WHAT IT COSTS
Entirely on your own Your sign, your showings, your contracts, your deadlines. No MLS, so no Zillow, Redfin or Homes.com. You write the disclosures and you carry the liability if something is missed.	\$0 plus your time
Paperwork only, with me For when you already have your buyer. I handle the purchase and sale agreement, the disclosures, the timelines, the addenda, title and escrow, and I get you to closing. You found the buyer, so you keep that part.	1%
Limited service listing An a la carte menu. At minimum it puts your house in the MLS, which is what puts you back on Zillow and everywhere else. Add what you want: photography, a lockbox, a sign, showing support, staging. Paid up front, not at closing.	You pick priced by the piece
A full listing Everything, including the parts that are hard to price: what it should list at, how it should look on day one, and someone whose job is to argue for your number when the offer comes in low.	Commission

one honest note.

The limited service and paperwork options are paid up front rather than out of proceeds, because they are services rather than a bet on a sale. Everything runs through my brokerage, Katrina Eileen Real Estate, the same as any other transaction in Washington.

WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY SIGNING

The paperwork is *the whole job.*

This is the part people underestimate, and it is the part that follows you after closing.

BEFORE IT GOES UP

- ☐ **Form 17, the seller disclosure.** Required on most Washington residential sales. What you knew and did not say is what comes back at you.
- ☐ Title report, pulled early, so an old lien or easement is not a surprise in week six
- ☐ Lead-based paint disclosure if the house was built before 1978
- ☐ Anything your water, septic or well requires
- ☐ What your HOA has to hand a buyer, and how long they take to produce it

ONCE YOU HAVE AN OFFER

- ☐ The purchase and sale agreement, and every addendum attached to it
- ☐ Earnest money, who holds it and what makes it refundable
- ☐ Inspection response and repair negotiation, on a clock
- ☐ Appraisal, and what happens if it comes in under contract price
- ☐ Financing and title contingency dates, each with a deadline you cannot miss
- ☐ Escrow instructions, the closing statement, and the keys

the real risk.

Almost nobody gets into trouble over the price. They get into trouble over a date they missed or a thing they did not disclose. Those are the two ways a sale falls apart or comes back months later, and both of them are paperwork.

Whether you offer to pay *the buyer's agent.*

It is optional. It is also the fastest way to make your house invisible in this market.

A buyer cannot finance their agent's commission. It is not part of the loan. So if you do not offer to pay it, that is roughly two and a half to three percent the buyer has to produce in cash, on top of the down payment, on top of closing costs.

On a \$700,000 house that is somewhere around \$17,500 to \$21,000 in cash that has to appear from somewhere.

Now put that in this market. Mortgage rates crossed 7% in September 2026, the first time since January 2025. On the Snohomish County median with 20% down, the payment is already about \$105 a month higher than it was two weeks earlier. Buyers are stretched and they know it.

Ask a buyer to find another twenty thousand dollars and they will not argue with you about it. They will just go see the house down the street that does offer it. And right now there are plenty of those houses.

What this does not mean. It is not a rule and nobody can tell you that you have to. It is a choice about how many buyers can physically afford to write on your house. Make it on purpose, with the number in front of you, rather than by leaving the field blank.

what I watched happen.

A seller I worked with this month relaunched with the buyer's agent commission offered, where the first attempt had not included it. Same house, same street, same family. It is the change I would make first.

When to stop *and hand it over.*

Switching is not a failure. It is information, and it takes a few days.

- 01 **Two weeks with no showings.** Not no offers. No showings. That means nobody is finding it or nobody likes what they see online, and both of those are fixable by someone else.
- 02 **Showings that go quiet.** People come through and you never hear back. Usually price, sometimes presentation, occasionally something about the house nobody will say to your face.
- 03 **You have a deadline.** A closing on the next place, a job, a lease, a family situation. Time pressure and a learning curve are a terrible combination.
- 04 **The offer arrives and you freeze.** Inspection response, an appraisal gap, a financing contingency. This is the moment where an afternoon of bad judgment costs more than a full commission.
- 05 **It is affecting your household.** I have watched this one land hardest. If it is making someone in the house miserable, that is a real cost even if it never shows up on the closing statement.

and about the house itself.

Your home is set up for living in. It is not set up for selling. Those are completely different things and it is not about your taste, it is about how a stranger moves through a room. One seller walked in after we staged hers and said: *"I love the decor. It's crazy how it changes the whole dynamics of the house."* That reaction is the whole argument, and it is hard to believe until you see it in your own rooms.

no pitch, promise.

Call me before you start, *not after.*

Even if you are going to do all of it yourself, a twenty minute conversation costs you nothing and usually saves you something. I will tell you honestly whether I think you can pull it off, what I would price it at, and which of the three routes actually fits your situation. If that turns out to be doing it alone, I will tell you that too.

THE FIRST CALL

PHONE & TEXT

425-250-9422

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SERVING

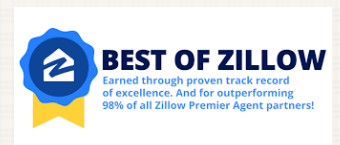
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Mukilteo

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your neighbor in real estate



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